e. Who did Watson see when he entered the room?

f. What were the instructions given by Holmes to Watson?

I heard the footsteps. I heard a voice say, "Holmes! Holmes! Can you hear me?"

"Is that you Mr. Smith?" Holmes whispered. "You know what is wrong with me. You are the only one in London who can cure me."

"Do you know the symptoms?" asked Smith.

"Only too well, Mr. Smith," and he described the symptoms.

"They are the same, Holmes," Smith said, "Poor Victor was a dead man on the fourth day -a strong and healthy young man. What a coincidence indeed!"

"I know that you did it," said Holmes.

"Well, you can't prove it."

"Give me water, please," Holmes groaned.

"Here." I heard Smith's voice.

"Cure me, please. Well, about Victor Savage's death. You did it. I'll forget everything, but cure me. I'll forget about it."

"You can forget or remember, just as you like. It doesn't matter to me how my nephew died. Watson said you got it from the Chinese sailors. Could there be any other reason?"

"I can't think. My mind is gone, help me," pleaded Holmes.

"Did anything come by post? A box by chance? On Wednesday?"

"Yes I opened it and there was a sharp spring inside it. A joke perhaps. It drew blood," said Holmes.

"No, it was not a joke, you fool, you've got it. Who asked you to cross my path? You knew too much about Victor's death. Your end is near, Holmes. I'll carry this box in my pocket. The last piece of evidence!"

"Turn up the gas, Smith," said Holmes in his natural voice.

"Yes I will, so that I can see you better." There was silence. Then I heard Smith say, "What's all this?"

"Successful acting," said Holmes, "for three days I didn't taste anything – neither food nor drink."

g. Why did Holmes plead with Smith?

h. Who was responsible for Victor Savage's death? What was the evidence for it?

There were footsteps outside. The door opened and I heard Inspector Morton's voice. "I arrest you on charge of murder," he said.

DO YOU KNOW?

Joseph Bell (1837-1911). He was a lecturer in medicine whose



detective approach to diagnosis inspired Arthur Conan Doyle's character *Sherlock Holmes*. The wider picture in Scotland at the time is set out in our Historical Timeline. Joseph Bell was born in Edinburgh.

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